

Digimon Adventure Side Trek

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1 - When Camping Goes Wrong

I - ???

In a brilliantly illuminated room, a single figure stood before a terminal, surrounded by a cloud of colorful glowing dust. There was a deep rumbling growl that seemed to come from all directions, and a wall of monitors displayed various angles on a sphere of what could best be described as a sphere of cloudy ice that seemed to pulse with light.

As the fair skinned figure with silver hair watched, one screen changed. It showed a knight clad in silver armor, his face entirely concealed except for two large eyes. "Seal status is nominal." The deep bass of his voice echoed in his own helmet.

The fair figure nodded and responded. "Affirmative, Knightmon." He proceeded to tap a button. "Clavis Angemon, status report?"

Another screen changed to show a figure as fair as the first, with red vestments beneath his armor, made of an unknown material but coated in pigments of the purest white and red that data could produce, with gilt bands and patterns plated onto it.

"The lock remains sound," the figure said. "Has there been a change in potential for rehabilitation?"

The fair figure shook his head softly. "No. Rather I feel uneasy about the patient."

As he spoke his eyes shifted to the northern pole of the sphere of ice. It felt as if something had happened. He manipulated his displays. "Northern pole. Confirm, is that. . ."

All three voices finished in unison. "... a crack!?"

"This is not nominal," Knightmon said.

"The lock is breaking," said Clavis Angemon.

The fair figure stood in silence for a moment. The light within his chamber blinked. "I understand. We will activate the contingency."

Knightmon's screen flickered. "Understood. Contingency signal prepared."

Clavis Angemon frowned, his screen going dark for half a second. "Very well. Our seal is compromised. Contingency approved."

The fair figure let out a deep sigh as a shadow flashed in his eyes. His hand pressed the gold and red hazard button. "The Dark Area is now self-contained. Our fates are in the hands of God now."

II - Genki

Hyalite Youth Camp
Montana, USA
31 July, 1999

A Japanese boy kicked the rocks along the side of the trail. He was supposed to be camping this weekend, but he wasn't supposed to be camping *here*. He brushed his dark blue bangs out of his eyes as he squatted on the side of the trail. He was supposed to be at the Mikami Canyon campsite in Tokyo, with his real schoolmates.

But his parents had moved to America. And not one of the places Genki knew about from TV and movies, they had moved to a place called Montana. A city named Bozeman. His father had accepted a foreign job, and now expected Genki to make brand new friends in a foreign country. They had made him join the school camping trip this week to try and get him to open up.

It wasn't that Genki couldn't do it. He knew English well enough, at least when he was reading or listening to it. But... he let out a heavy sigh as he looked at the boy who had taken it on himself to chaperone him around. Ben Cohen was a tanned boy with wild, tightly coiled green hair.

"Yo, it's getting pretty chilly," Ben said. He bent down and sat on the dirt next to Genki. "They're cancelling lake activities for the rest of the day. No swimming this afternoon. You wanna go back to the cabin for a jacket?"

Genki shrugged and looked up at the sky. It was cold. The weather had been nice for the rest of the week, but it had been strange all day. "Iie," Genki said softly. "Jaketto wa iranai."

"Guessing that's a no," Ben said, letting out a deep sigh. "Look, I know you understand me. And our parents are friends, so can we just try..."

"No," Genki said flatly. He let his accent drip heavily. "Not your friend."

"Fine," Ben said. "Just until we go home tomorrow, can you pretend you don't hate everything about Bozeman?"

Genki took a deep breath and stared at the sky. He didn't say anything. If he didn't make friends, maybe he'd convince his parents to send him home to live with his grandfather.

III - Kim

Red-blond hair tied in pigtails and bright blue eyes stared up at the sky. The girl was halfway up the rock wall, hanging from her harness, gripping onto the stones bolted to give her a path. She was shorter than most kids her age. Much shorter, but when she was climbing, she didn't feel short.

"Bates, are you stuck?"

"I'm fine, just catching my breath," she shouted down to the teacher. She reached out for the next rock and grinned. She loved climbing. It made her feel more normal. She picked up her pace as much as she could without sacrificing safety.

She didn't have any friends in her class. There were a few other girls who were nice to her, like Lisa, one of the girls who only liked horses because it was a normal thing for girls to like, or Rachel, who had a bit of a temper but didn't try to make Kim act girlier.

"Hey, don't go too fast, Bates!" The teacher was worried. Everybody always underestimated her.

"I do this all the time," she shouted back, holding her position while turning her head to glance down. As her head tilted back up she caught sight of something that shouldn't be in the sky on July 31.

A single snowflake floated down past her.

Sure, it was cold for July, but was it really that cold?

She felt her grip slipping, and pushed off the wall with her legs. She let the rope catch her harness, and as she swung back in she took a firm grip of the nearest rocks to her hands.

She secured her grip and looked back down. Rachel gave her a thumbs up.

IV - Ben

Ben was shivering in his bunk at night. It was unseasonably cold, and the campsite hadn't thought to provide winter blankets for a summer camping trip. The day had been especially boring due to the mysterious cold snap, and it was only getting colder overnight.

He climbed out of bed, pulled on the warmest pants and jacket he had, and walked quietly to the cabin door. He grabbed his shoes and opened the door gently. If he couldn't sleep, at least he could move. Sitting on the top step of the patio, he slipped his hiking boots on and looked towards the lake. The moon was bright tonight.

“Can’t sleep?”

The voice came from near the edge of the patio. A glint of light hair showed as a girl stepped forward.

“Cohen, right? Ben?”

Ben nodded. “Yeah, and you’re...”

“Kim,” she said. “Going into fifth grade. We’re not in the same class.”

Ben sighed. He was going into fifth grade too. “Alright, so you’re sneaking out too. Headed to the lake?”

“I heard it froze solid,” she said, as if to offer an explanation. “In less than a day. Crazy, hm?”

They walked together. Ben noted how short she was – she only stood about to his chin. If she hadn’t claimed to be an incoming fifth grader, he might have thought of her as a 2nd, or maybe 3rd, grade student.

“I guess so,” Ben said. “Must be one of those crazy climate swings.”

“Or maybe it’s spirits,” Kim said with a playful lilt to her tone. “Maybe the ancestors of the natives are trying to drive us out. Or what if it’s aliens doing an experiment on us?”

Spirits and aliens? Kim clearly had a wild imagination.

“I doubt it,” Ben said. He rolled his shoulders in a shrug. “At least, I’ve never really bought into ghosts and monsters. I can’t rule out aliens, though.”

Kim pointed to the edge of the lake. There was another figure standing there, dark hair, no jacket, loose athletic style pants hanging down the legs. Whoever it was, they were staring up at the sky.

Ben nodded to Kim. “Looks like someone else about our age,” he said.

“I can’t tell if it’s a boy or a girl.”

“Does it matter?”

They got closer to the edge of the lake and saw that it was, indeed, frozen solid. Maybe not deeply frozen, but there wasn’t the least bit of motion across the surface. The naturally uneven wavy surface was as still as a photo, and it almost made Ben question if he was really awake right now.

As they got close to the third child, they heard a single word.

“Aurora.”

The third child pointed to the sky. Kim looked up and Ben could see her pupils going wide. He followed the gesture and saw an absolutely uncanny imitation of the aurora borealis, entirely out of season. The almost neon, fluorescent green seemed like it was forming the walls of a canyon in the sky.

“This can’t be real,” he said as he stared up feeling a sense of awe. “It’s practically August!”

As they stared up at the sky, three brilliant lights appeared in the impossible aurora. In only a few seconds, it became obvious that they were shooting stars, falling out of the heavens.

“Inseki. . .”

Ben didn’t know the word, but he recognized the voice now. Genki.

“Wait. . . are they heading. . .”

“Koko wa. . .”

“Right for us!” Ben shouted, reaching to grab Genki’s hand and pull him out of the way. “Move!”

It only took a moment before the shooting stars shot into the beach at the shoreline, though instead of crashing explosively they shot into the ground more like airsoft pellets into a pillow. The lack of dramatic impact force was the only reason Ben felt confident enough to investigate.

Three holes were dented into the soft beach sand, maybe an inch or two deep, lit from inside by whatever the shooting stars were. They were about 3 inches across. Incredibly small, it was amazing that they had even survived falling through the atmosphere.

“Wow!” Kim had made her way up to the holes too now. She was crouching next to one of them when the shooting stars did something even more unbelievable: They started to float up into the air.

“Suge!” Genki ranted in Japanese as he came closer to the holes.

Ben stared at the shooting stars—no, they weren’t stars or rocks. They were like plastic, a pale, light colored plastic with dark-colored buttons and even a small antenna. They had an ergonomic shapes, and even had some strange symbols carved into the face.

He reached out for the one nearest to him, and felt his stomach lurch as it seemed like reality itself vanished from beneath his feet.

V - Genki

Genki blinked several times. It was the middle of the day, and it felt like he was lying on the ground. As his fingers tried to grip, he noted that the ground felt unusual somehow. More like the texture of cooked rice, firm but with a certain sort of squishy give.

As he rose into a sitting position, he noticed that everything almost seemed to look artificial. As if he was inside a bento lunchbox that was overly decorated. The ground looked like a clumpy brown sugar. The grass almost looked like it

was made of plastic. And the trees looked blocky, like they were made out of small cubes of plastic or sugar that had been dyed to resemble the red of a tree's bark.

Genki was about to stand up when he realized that something was sitting on his legs. A small plush-like furry thing, with brown fur and floppy squared-off ears. It looked like just a stuffed animal that was just a head, but it wriggled in his lap. "Genki?"

His eyes went wide. "Wh... who said that?"

The plush ball wriggled more and looked up. Its mouth opened and its eyes went wide. "Genki! Genki! You're awake!"

"Wh-what are you!?"

"Of course, I'm being so rude. I'm Koinumon," the fluffy creature said. "And I'm your friend and partner!"

VI - Kim

Kim found herself lying on an uneven surface. It was partially hard like rock, and partly loose like brown sugar, with a pebbly consistency to it as she tried to stand up. The sky was brilliant. The trees were tall and thick. And once she was standing up, she could hardly tell the ground was even different from real ground.

"Ki~im!" A voice was calling for her, a voice that didn't quite feel like a boy or a girl. "Ki~im!" Still it sounded caring, like Ron when caught her climbing the rafters in the barn. And with less disapproval, too.

"Hello!?" She looked around to try and find the source of the voice, or let it find her.

It took only a moment of playing Marco Polo before a small plushy ball-like creature with large, but friendly, amber eyes found her. It had blue and white fur, with a brushed steel helmet covering the upper half of itself. Its small fox-like tail had jagged stripes, and the two horns of its helmet seemed to move a bit like ears or TV antennas.

It let out a cheerful shout and bounced its way up to Kimberly. "Ki~im! I'm so glad to hear you! I'm your protector, Caprimon!"

"Protector?" Kim smiled and giggled. She had always wanted a pet of her own, but this one could talk, which made it way cooler. "So where am I?"

"You're in the Digital World," Caprimon said. "And I've been waiting for you for such a long time."

Kimberly nodded slowly. "Well, why don't I climb this tree to figure out what we should do next?"

VII - Ben

Ben was not having this. He was being chased by a stone that just rolled along the ground like a die, being told that it had been waiting for him, and they were meant to work together.

“Just leave me alone!”

Destiny. He hated the idea of destiny, at least in the spiritual sense. He didn’t buy into divine plans. He didn’t buy into the existence of the divine, for that matter.

“But we are partners, Ben!”

As he fled, he spotted a reddish-orange color and felt sure he’d found Kim. he turned towards it, and broke into a clearing of stone statues and giant flaming orange boar, shouting:

“Kim! I’m so glad to see you, have you seen Genki?”

As the last word left his lips he recognized that this boar was definitely not Kim.

But it was looking at him now, and it didn’t look pleased or happy. It only took seconds before the boar as large as Ben started to charge, its mane bursting into flames.

To Be Continued

Digimon Analyzer: Koinumon

Koinumon is an In-Training Digimon with a Lesser mammalian form. It looks like a marshmallow dog head with floppy ears, and will be your best friend for life if you let it! It can’t do a lot in combat, but if forced to defend itself it can bark so much it will drive any foe back (**Barking Beef**) or spit out a cloud of bubbles made of stomach acid (**Acid Bubbles**). Koinumon are quite rare, and they often form packs with other In-Training Digimon to keep safe from larger Digimon who want their hidden powers!

Navigation

- ← Previous Chapter
- Next Chapter →